NO. 154 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

THURSDAY 5 NOVEMBER 2026



THE NAMEPLATE THE ARREST WARRANT NAMES (P3)

THE WORLD

Prabowo sacks his chief of staff, arrested over wiretapping the president; 20,000 troops enter Jakarta

SINGAPORE

Parliament raises the haze fine tenfold to twenty million; in twelve years the Act has fined nobody

THE LONG READ

Uzbekistan's central bank priced one iPhone and found credit at 66.5 per cent

Source: Agence France-Presse via Al Jazeera, 4 November 2026 — General Listyo Sigit Prabowo, identified by his own nameplate.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 154

Contents

p3 The World — the police chief accused of tapping the president
p4 The World — the minister resigns; the control room is still short
p5 Singapore — a tenfold fine on a law that has never fined
p6 The Atelier — the same seven candlepower, at twice the price
p7 Technology — a record quarter, guided to a thinner margin
p8 The Home Lab — the store moves inside, the warning stays
p9 The Kit — a lovely laptop and an unfinished system
p10 The Good Life — $3,799, and nobody has measured it
p11 Screen & Sound — number one on twenty variants
p12–13 The Family Desk — the hour, and the ban
p14 The Macro Desk — eight per cent off a war that has not ended
p15–17 The Rabbit Hole — dog agility, and the handler who cannot run
p18 Fitness — the antioxidant that made it worse
p19–20 The Diary — a second night added, and eleven returning names
p21–23 The Long Read — the posters say nought per cent

THE MISSING MECHANISM. Everything in this issue is announced without the part that would make it work. A treason named with no motive found (p3). A fine raised tenfold while the evidence route stays shut (p5). A minister resigning from a control room still twenty per cent short (p4). A record quarter guided to a thinner margin (p7). And a nought-per-cent poster over a sixty-six-per-cent rate (p21).

FROM THE DESK

"There is nothing more deceptive than an obvious fact."

Sherlock Holmes, in Arthur Conan Doyle's *The Boscombe Valley Mystery*, 1891[1]

Which is the whole of p21, where the obvious fact is a poster reading nought per cent and the measured one is sixty-six and a half.

THE STRIP · AT WEDNESDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[2]	4.90%	▼ 5bp
US 10-year real[2]	2.64%	+83bp yr
VWRA	$190.64	▲ 1.36%
AGGU	$5.832	▲ 0.33%
Gold spot	$4,066	▲ 3.4%
Bitcoin	$80,216	▲ 3.7%
Brent[3]	$95.06	▼ 8.2%
USD/SGD	1.2788	▼ 0.19%
Straits Times	5,268.63	▼ 0.01%

Brent fell sixteen per cent in three sessions (p14). Gold and bitcoin are evening spot reads, not exchange closes. Not advice.[2]

FROM THE ARCHIVE · NO. 147, AND THE PEG THIS DESK SAID IT WAS WAITING FOR

A Thursday evergreen, since the Index runs Fridays and the Scoreboard Saturdays. Seven issues ago this desk led on the collision near Urda and wrote down what would earn the story a second slot.[4]

The ledger line read: the recorder findings, a resignation, or a charge. On Tuesday the resignation arrived, and the page it earned is p4 — a delta, not a re-telling.

That is the whole purpose of writing the next peg down. Without it, a running story either vanishes or gets re-explained from the beginning every few days, which is the failure this magazine gates against.

It is also why p20 leads on a count rather than a discovery — eleven of the twelve venues on this month's openings list turned out to be names this column had already met.

It also set the hobby on p15. Dog agility was one of three candidates printed at the foot of No. 153; with no editor note and no reader vote since, the strongest of the three ran.

And it is why the boxes on this page are allowed three columns. These are a strip, not an article — running prose never leaves the two-column measure.

The same ledger discipline retired a desk once. Property ran until No. 73 and was cut because the reader skipped it; The Atelier has occupied p6 every morning since, and has now worked through eighty purchase categories.

Two of today's pages exist only because a host refused us. Where a source would not serve this desk we print that on the page rather than quietly thinning the story — p21 reads an entire central bank through somebody else's reporting, and says so twice.

SOURCES 1 Arthur Conan Doyle, "The Boscombe Valley Mystery", *The Strand Magazine*, October 1891; the line is Holmes's, to Watson, on the Boscombe Pool case. 2 Levels at Wednesday 4 November's close, each sourced instrument by instrument on p14, where the United States Treasury's own daily par and real yield curves supply both yield lines. **Gold and bitcoin are evening spot reads, not exchange closes.** 3 A market read, not an exchange settlement; the 30 October level behind the three-session fall is implied from published percentage moves. 4 This magazine's own Coverage Ledger and Issue Log, Nos. 147 and 149.

THE WORLD · INDONESIA & ITS POLICE

Prabowo sacks chief of staff Listyo Sigit, arrested over wiretapping the president

Police seized eleven phones, an iPad and four flash drives, and questioned ten witnesses. A day later the army moved more than 20,000 soldiers into Jakarta.

President Prabowo Subianto dismissed his chief of staff, General Listyo Sigit Prabowo, on Wednesday 4 November, a day after Indonesia's national police announced they had arrested him over the illegal tapping of the president's own telephone. Two other serving police generals were arrested with him.[1]

A wiretap is the secret interception of somebody's calls and messages. The man accused of ordering them against the head of state ran Indonesia's whole police force for five years, until last month. It is the sharpest break inside the security apparatus of Singapore's largest neighbour since Prabowo took office, and by Wednesday there were soldiers in Jakarta.[2]

The allegation is procedural. Police say numbers were entered into the force's lawful-interception system without verification, and taps ordered outside a police regulation of 2010; the targets are said to run from the president and cabinet ministers to journalists and business figures, between 2025 and this year, and last month the suspects allegedly ordered the files deleted. **Asep Safrudin**, the force's most senior detective, said it ran "*without any legal basis*".[1]

Three statutes are cited: **article 258** of the new criminal code, unlawful interception, up to **ten years**; **article 332**, up to **six**; and **article 32** of the Electronic Information and Transactions Law, for deleting electronic information, up to **eight**. Arrested with him were **Inspector-General Ahrie Sonta Nasution**, head of the police legal division, and **Inspector-General Eko Hadi Santoso**. Nobody is charged; none of the three has spoken.[1]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Sets the palace's language against the cabinet's: "*certain rogue individuals*" whose conduct "*may… be considered an act tending towards treason*" — beside a minister who says no motive is established.[2]

SYDNEY — ABC

Treats it as police procedure and counts the evidence: eleven phones, an iPad, four flash drives, ten witnesses. It reports no rift and no treason finding.[1]

KUALA LUMPUR — AFP

Reads it as a factional reckoning: Listyo was made police chief by Joko Widodo and had led the force in Widodo's own mayoral city.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT JAKARTA SAID ABOUT LISTYO'S ARREST

Former president **Susilo Bambang Yudhoyono** posted that Prabowo should "*restore civility to our politics*". **Sugiono**, secretary-general of Prabowo's own Gerindra party, called the affair insubordination inside the government. **Amnesty International Indonesia** asked the authorities to publish the list of people tapped.

THE SCEPTIC · WHY LISTYO'S CASE MAY NOT BE TREASON

The palace reached for treason; the cabinet will not go there. Yusril Ihza Mahendra, senior minister for legal affairs, says investigators found no indication of it and no motive established. Nobody is charged, no recipient is named, and the target list exists only as a police description of itself. The navy puts Wednesday's troop movement down to training near the capital, so a rival reading survives: a factional purge dressed as a criminal file. **What would settle it:** the charge sheet and the published target list.[1]

20,000

SOLDIERS THE ARMED FORCES PUT INTO JAKARTA ON 4 NOVEMBER — "A NORMAL OCCURRENCE", SAYS THEIR SPOKESMAN[2]

SOURCES 1 ABC News (Australia), 4 November 2026, read at source: the three officers' names and ranks, the seized items, the witness counts, the three statutes and their maximum terms, the interception system and the 2010 regulation. **It is the only outlet of the three that carries the article numbers.** 2 Al Jazeera, 4 November 2026, read at source, for the dismissal, the presidential spokesman's words, the detective's quote and the Jakarta deployment. **The 20,000 figure is not attributed to a named official in the report.** 3 Free Malaysia Today carrying Agence France-Presse, 4 November 2026, for the party, civil-society and former-president reactions and the appointment history. **Single-sourced on the Prabowo–Widodo framing, which ABC does not report.** 4 Indonesian-language wires and the national police's own pages returned nothing readable to this desk on 5 November; the search index is a day behind the story.

AROUND THE DESKS · SPAIN AFTER URDA

Óscar Puente resigns as Spain's transport minister six days after Urda

Adif's Madrid control centre cleared the express to proceed at 08:36 on 28 October, eighteen minutes before it struck a stalled train and killed 69 people.

Óscar Puente resigned as Spain's transport minister on Tuesday 3 November, announcing it at the end of an hours-long appearance before the standing deputation of Congress in Madrid, six days after a high-speed collision near Urda in Toledo province killed **69** people. His words: "A *transport minister… cannot remain in office after two accidents of this seriousness in less than a year.*"[1]

It removes a senior minister twenty-six days before a general election, and it moves the argument from who is to blame to what failed. This desk reported the crash in No. 147 and the response in No. 149, and the ledger set a resignation as the next peg. The delta is what the week added: a preliminary finding, a union case about staffing, and two strike dates.[1]

The investigator's wording is systemic, not individual. Spain's accident authority puts the impact at **160 to 200 km/h** pending the recorders, and says "*the sequence of malfunctions, instructions, and actions eventually led to the collision*". The sequence: at **08:30** a fault disabled automatic train protection across roughly **63km**, halting six trains; at **08:36** Madrid authorised the express to proceed; at **08:41** and **08:48** the stalled driver reported she could not restart. The express was never told to stop. Protocol in such a failure is sight-driving at **40 km/h**.[2]

Puente's own parting measures point at the same seam: better control-centre staffing, faster installation of the European signalling replacement, and an artificial-intelligence agent on driver-to-controller radio, which he said would make Spain the first country to use one. The government declared three days of mourning and a **€30m** package, with **€72,121** to each bereaved family and the same again in advance compensation.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT SPAIN'S CONTROLLERS SAY ABOUT URDA

The people who do the job have gone on the attack. **José Carlos Gutiérrez**, who coordinates the rail-controllers' union, says the leaked recordings may be incomplete, has complained to the investigating judge at Orgaz, and puts the Madrid centre's shortfall at about **20 per cent** across sixteen positions. A second union warns that staff over-exertion "*cannot become a permanent solution*". **Raquel Ayllón**, a union leader, told Reuters that "*human error is being criticized and questioned very quickly.*" Drivers strike on **10 November**, with a safety strike pushed for the **17th**.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHETHER PUENTE'S RESIGNATION ANSWERS URDA AT ALL

A resignation personalises a systems failure, and there is a live factual dispute underneath it. One account has the centre clearing the express for normal running; the consolidated record has it authorising sight-running at up to 40 km/h without confirming the line was clear. If the second is right, the primary failure was a train exceeding sight-speed, and the "the controller cleared it" framing collapses onto the cab. Puente also defended the old signalling's reliability and called the European replacement a matter of interoperability — while the contract to finish it on this line by early 2026 remains undone. **What would settle it:** the recorder download and the full report.[2]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Washington will suspend South Africa and Rwanda from duty-free African trade access on 1 January 2027. South Africa shipped about **$1.7bn** under the programme in 2025, roughly a tenth of its exports to America.[5]

South Africans voted in local elections on 4 November at 23,696 stations with a record **29.2 million** registered; results are due Sunday.[5]

North Korea fired several missiles toward the Sea of Japan on 4 November, its fourth launch in a month, as Kim Yo Jong dismissed the American attribution of the **$6bn** Binance theft.[5]

SOURCES 1 Euronews, 3 November 2026, and PBS NewsHour carrying the Associated Press, both read at source, for the resignation, the setting and the quoted reason. 2 The preliminary finding of Spain's independent transport accident authority as carried by CGTN from Reuters, 30 October 2026, and Euronews's minute-by-minute account of 29 October, both read at source. **The dispute over what the controller actually authorised is unresolved between those accounts and is printed as a dispute.** 3 Al Jazeera, 4 November 2026, for the aid package and the per-family figures; the January Adamuz toll from the consolidated public record. **The nationality breakdown of the Urda dead is single-sourced and is not printed.** 4 Mundiario, 2 November 2026, read at source, for the union coordinator, the complaint, the staffing shortfall and the strike dates; the Reuters quotation via CGTN, 30 October. **Several Spanish national dailies, the BBC and the Associated Press all refused this desk directly.** 5 Al Jazeera, 2 to 4 November 2026, each item read at source.

SINGAPORE · THE HAZE BILL

Singapore's Parliament raises the maximum haze fine tenfold to twenty million dollars

Grace Fu took the bill through all three readings in one sitting under a Certificate of Urgency. In twelve years the original Act has produced no prosecution.

Parliament passed amendments to the Transboundary Haze Pollution Act on Wednesday 4 November, lifting the maximum fine on a company linked to haze-causing fires from **$2m to $20m** and the daily rate from **$100,000 to $1m**. All three readings were taken in one sitting under a Certificate of Urgency.[1]

The reason the increase matters less than it sounds is the record behind it. The Act dates from 2014 and has produced no prosecution, no conviction and no fine. The binding problem was never the size of the penalty; it is getting evidence out of another country about fires on land Singapore's courts cannot visit. The amendments do widen the net — the Act now reaches conduct that merely *risks* haze reaching Singapore, so the smoke no longer has to arrive — and they make the offences arrestable and let a trial proceed without the accused in the room.[1]

There is also a new route that does not need a criminal standard of proof. The National Environment Agency may now sue for a civil penalty of up to **$10m** with the Public Prosecutor's consent, and no entity pays both a civil and a criminal penalty for one case. Courts may add a sum equal to the profit gained or the loss avoided.[2]

The enforcement already under way sets the scale. The agency served notices on **ten Indonesian companies** — seven on 16 October, three on 19 October — and on **ten Singapore-registered** palm-oil and forestry companies, all of which agreed to appoint assessors. Grace Fu told the House that **three of the four entities still under investigation from the 2015 haze have been identified again in this episode**, and that those cases lapsed "*due to procedural issues*". The episode is easing: the 24-hour index read 60 to 70 island-wide at four this morning.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT MPS ASKED GRACE FU ABOUT THE HAZE FINE

Eileen Chong, a Workers' Party non-constituency MP, put the record into the chamber: "*More than 10 years have passed, there has not been a single prosecution, a single conviction, a single dollar in fines*", and asked "*why did we have to wait 10 years?*" **David Hoe** of the governing party put the sum the other way round: $20m is about four per cent of profit for a company earning $500m a year.

THE SCEPTIC · WHY A TWENTY-MILLION FINE MAY STILL COLLECT NOTHING

The bill raises the penalty and leaves the constraint where it was. Alan Khee-Jin Tan of the National University of Singapore's law faculty argues that Singapore will in practice "*wait for Indonesia to finger certain companies first*", because the evidence exists only if Indonesian authorities investigate and share it, and the obvious defence is that the fires began outside the concession. **Helena Varkkey** of the University of Malaya calls it "*influence without enforcement, rather than straightforward failure*". Fu conceded as much: "*There is no guarantee of a successful prosecution.*" **What would settle it:** a charge, or a dollar collected, by the end of 2027.[5]

$0

COLLECTED UNDER THE ACT IN TWELVE YEARS, AGAINST A NEW CEILING OF TWENTY MILLION[4]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Car-loan caps were extended to individually owned private-hire cars from 30 October — 70 per cent of value where the open market value is $20,000 or less, 60 per cent above it, and a seven-year ceiling on the term.[6]

The second round of free mask collection opened on 23 October and dropped the senior age threshold from 67 to 60; close to **30 per cent** of eligible residents had collected by 29 October.[3]

SOURCES 1 The Minister for Sustainability and the Environment's second-reading opening speech of 4 November 2026, read at source on the ministry's own site, for the penalty figures, the Certificate of Urgency and the widened scope. 2 The National Environment Agency's release of 4 November 2026, read at source, for the civil-penalty route, the profit-disgorgement power, the arrest and service provisions and the designated-entity penalties. 3 The agency's release of 23 October 2026 naming the notices served; the minister's closing speech of 4 November for the assessors and the 2015 overlap; the agency's own real-time pollutant index read directly from the national data service at 04:00 on 5 November 2026; and the ministry's parliamentary reply of 3 November on the mask rounds. 4 Mothership, 4 November 2026, and Yahoo News Singapore's report of the debate. **The Straits Times, CNA and the Business Times all refused this desk, so the chamber exchanges reach this page through secondary reports.** 5 Al Jazeera, 22 October 2026, and Mongabay, October 2026, both read at source. **Reddit, HardwareZone and Bogleheads were all unreachable, so no forum sentiment appears on this page.** 6 The Ministry of Energy, Trade and Industry's own newsroom — renamed from Trade and Industry with effect from 1 October 2026.

THE ATELIER · OIL LAMPS & LANTERNS

Feuerhand and Dietz lanterns make the same seven candlepower at twice the price

W.T. Kirkman's own catalogue rates both at 7 candlepower on a half-inch wick. The extra $21 buys galvanised steel, a Schott globe and nine more hours.

Oil lamps and hurricane lanterns make light in three different ways, and this page is about telling them apart before you spend. A dead-flame lamp draws air only through baffles under the burner and gives much less light. A tubular lantern feeds air down side tubes, and the distinction that matters is **cold blast**, where only fresh air reaches the flame, against **hot blast**, which recirculates some spent. W.T. Kirkman's figure: cold blast gives about **twice** the light at the same wick size, hot blast burns about **ten per cent** longer. Buy nothing but cold blast.[1]

After that the wick decides everything, because light scales with its width and not with the price. Half an inch gives seven candlepower, seven-eighths twelve to fourteen, a centre-draught round wick forty to fifty. What money buys instead is metal and glass. **Feuerhand's Baby Special 276** is galvanised sheet steel — zinc corrodes before the steel does, the right specification at eighty per cent humidity — with a **Suprax** borosilicate globe, reorderable at **$15.95** as part 1276. Painted tinplate, most of the cheap tier and most vintage stock, blooms rust at the crimped seams within a season on a balcony.[2]

And know who made it. **Dietz** left New York for Hong Kong in 1956, China in 1982 and Jiangsu in 2005, and still sells on American railroad romance. **Aladdin's** brass went to England in 1963 and its burners to Hong Kong in 1977; the trademark has been sold twice since 1999. **Vermont Lanterns** says its brass is "*made in India to our specification*" with inspection in Vermont; Kirkman sells the same Indian brass openly labelled from **$162.50**. In Singapore kerosene costs **S$2.88** for 400ml and needs no licence under 200 litres, but there is **no authorised dealer for any of these makers here**, and Feuerhand itself says the 276 is for "*balcony, terrace, and garden*".[5]

WHAT A WICK IS WORTH

LANTERN	WICK	CP	BURN
Dietz #76 — $28.95	1/2″	7	11 hr
Feuerhand 276 — $49.95	1/2″	7	20 hr
Dietz #80 Blizzard — $49.95	7/8″	12–14	27 hr

THE CHATTER · WHAT COLLECTORS SAY ABOUT PETROMAX AND DIETZ

On Classic Pressure Lamps, **Mackburner** wrote in 2012 that "*quality control has always been a problem with any Chinese made lanterns and the modern Petromax is no exception*", sending buyers to pre-1970s German or Portuguese units. In March 2022 **chocki** examined a Chinese-built one: "*I'm not convinced about the 500 candle power output*". **MYN**, same thread: "*not made with the same machines and toolings as the originals*".[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY FEUERHAND'S PREMIUM BUYS NO EXTRA LIGHT

Feuerhand itself prices the answer. The firm that makes the best hurricane lantern in the world sells an **LED version of the same silhouette at €67.90** against **€39.90** for the kerosene original — twenty-eight euros more for no flame. And the lumens never follow the money. **Check the box, too:** one European retailer's listing says "country of origin: China" on the page calling it German-made. **What would settle it:** a photometric comparison nobody publishes.[4]

NEXT ON THE BENCH · VOTE FOR TOMORROW'S CATEGORY

Carbon-steel & cast-iron frying pans — gauge, seasoning and the French forges that stamp for everyone.

Wallets & card cases — shell cordovan against calf, and the ateliers that cut for the famous names.

Dehumidifiers & air treatment — the one appliance a tropical flat actually wears out.

SOURCES 1 W.T. Kirkman's own technical, fuel and catalogue pages, read at source November 2026, for the cold- and hot-blast mechanism, the candlepower and burn figures, the wick widths and every price in the table. **The company's primary domain returned HTTP 503 to this desk; its catalogue site served everything.** 2 Feuerhand's own product pages for the 276's material, capacity and part numbers; Aladdin's own corporate history page for the 1963, 1977, 1999 and 2015 moves; Vermont Lanterns' own description of its Indian manufacture; DHR's own site and its American distributor for the marine lamps. 3 Classic Pressure Lamps threads of March 2012 and 24 March 2022, and SurvivalBlog, 28 August 2011, all read at source, handles as displayed. **Reddit blocked this desk outright, so r/oillamps, r/preppers and r/BuyItForLife are unread and nothing is attributed to them.** 4 Feuerhand's own pricing of its kerosene and LED models; retailer listings for the dissenting buyer comment and the contradictory origin statement. 5 Teck Cheong Hardware's own shop listing for the kerosene prices; the Civil Defence Force's own exempt-quantity table for the 200-litre household figure. **The statute's own schedule returned HTTP 403, so the class assignment rests on a 2008 ministerial reply.**

TECHNOLOGY · AMD'S RECORD QUARTER

Lisa Su reports a record $13.4bn quarter at AMD and guides to $17bn

Lisa Su told analysts on 3 November that revenue should grow more than 80 per cent in 2027, with server revenue doubling; data-centre sales nearly doubled to $8.5bn.

AMD said on Tuesday 3 November that it sold more in the three months to late September than in any quarter of its history — $13.4bn, up 45 per cent on a year earlier — and told investors to expect roughly **$17bn** in the quarter now running. Its chief executive, **Lisa Su**, said the company expects to grow more than 80 per cent next year.[1]

The reason this is a story about more than one company's accounts is that AMD is the only firm of real size selling an alternative to Nvidia's chips for building artificial-intelligence systems, and until this quarter it had largely promised rather than delivered. Two terms carry the rest: a data centre is the warehouse of computers that runs these services for everyone else, and a rack is one cabinet of those computers, sold complete. The business is now conducted by the cabinet, not the chip.[1]

The segment numbers are where the quarter sits. Data Center took **$8,546m**, up **97 per cent** year on year and now **64 per cent** of the company, at a 34 per cent operating margin. Client was **$2,949m**, Embedded **$1,109m**, and Gaming **$773m**, **down 40**. Gross margin was 54 per cent reported and 56 adjusted; earnings **$1.46** a diluted share against **$2.09** adjusted. Su said volume shipments of the MI455X accelerator began in the quarter.[1]

One line in the accounts is new and will grow. Reported earnings carried a **$1.1bn** non-cash charge from customer-agreement warrants as the new accelerators began shipping, and the chief financial officer, **Jean Hu**, told the call that "*these quarterly non-cash fair value adjustments are expected to increase*". Anthropic, Meta, Microsoft, OpenAI and Oracle are named as running work on the first Helios systems; Europe's supercomputing agency picked an AMD accelerator for its own machine.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT ANALYSTS ASKED LISA SU ON THE CALL

Nobody doubted the demand; four people in a row doubted the supply and the price of it. Tom O'Malley of Barclays asked whether the 80-per-cent growth is backed by wafers, packaging, substrates and memory. **Vivek Arya** of Bank of America asked whether AMD's anchor customers can finance and house roughly three gigawatts of 2027 deployment. **Joshua Buchalter** of TD Cowen asked whether memory-cost inflation erodes the per-gigawatt framing. **Stacy Rasgon** of Bernstein asked for 2027 margins and Hu declined: "*Right now, I actually don't have that visibility.*"[2]

THE SCEPTIC · AMD'S OWN GUIDANCE ARGUES AGAINST ITS QUARTER

The bear case is on AMD's own page. Fourth-quarter gross margin is guided to about **55 per cent** — roughly a point *below* the 56 just reported — while revenue is guided up 27 per cent sequentially. The part that is growing is the lower-margin part. Gaming fell 40 per cent, so one segment with a handful of customers is the whole growth engine. And the reported figure now carries a billion-dollar warrant charge the finance chief says will get bigger, widening the gap between what AMD earns and what it reports. **What would settle it:** a fourth quarter near $17bn followed by first-quarter guidance below a 55 per cent margin, which would make this a volume story and not a profit one.[1]

97%

YEAR-ON-YEAR GROWTH IN DATA-CENTRE REVENUE, NOW 64 PER CENT OF THE COMPANY[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Qualcomm reported its fourth quarter on 4 November with revenue of $10.32bn, down 8 per cent — but automotive up **89 per cent** to $1.99bn, the opposite shape to AMD's quarter.[3]

Mistral published open weights for a one-trillion-parameter model under its own ecosystem licence, claiming 41 per cent on a terminal-agent benchmark, thirteen points above its preview.[3]

SOURCES 1 AMD's third-quarter results release of 3 November 2026, read at source on the company's own investor-relations system: every segment figure, margin, earnings number and the fourth-quarter guidance. 2 The earnings-call transcript of 3 November 2026, read at source, for Su's and Hu's quotations and all four analyst questions as asked; and AMD's newsroom post of the same date for the named Helios customers and the acquisitions. **That the warrants belong to one named customer is widely reported but is not stated in either document, so this desk does not name the counterparty. The per-gigawatt revenue figure is an analyst's premise in his question, not an AMD disclosure, and is not printed as one.** 3 Qualcomm's own earnings exhibit filed with the Securities and Exchange Commission, 4 November 2026; Mistral's own release page. **A reported cancellation of an Oracle–Tencent chip-rental agreement appears on aggregators only and is held out of this page.**

THE HOME LAB · HOME ASSISTANT'S MARKETPLACE

Home Assistant builds the community add-on store into itself and retires its installer

Release 2026.11 shipped on 4 November with 38 new integrations, 44 sections of breaking changes, and the first support for cameras on the Matter standard.

The free software that a great many people use to run the lights, locks and heating in their homes shipped its November update on Wednesday 4 November, and it ended a nine-year division of labour. The add-on store that almost every serious user installed by hand on the first day is now simply part of the program, built in, under a menu called Marketplace.[1]

This matters to anyone who has been told to install the community thing first. Until this week the official software shipped with no way to fetch extensions written by volunteers, and a separate project filled the gap. That gap is now closed and the volunteer project has stopped shipping, so the extensions arrive on the same schedule as the program itself. The update also shows live video from any camera built to the industry's common smart-home standard, instead of one maker's app per camera.[1]

The mechanics are kinder than the change sounds. Installed items stay installed and keep updating, custom repositories and update entities carry over, and old links redirect; the migration needs no action. What ends is the separate installer, which stops at this version — a standalone install is no longer possible and the old project gets no further releases. **Joakim Sørensen**, who wrote it, pinned the notice on his own repository on 16 October: "*HACS is becoming part of Home Assistant… Development now happens in Home Assistant itself, so this repository is no longer the place for new work.*" Submissions still go to the defaults list.[2]

Around it, a dense release. Matter 1.5 cameras arrive with live WebRTC video, snapshots and an entity reflecting privacy mode. The Zigbee stack gains Green Power for batteryless switches. A new protocol family, LoRaWAN, lands with ChirpStack and The Things Network. Nineteen integrations reached the top quality tier, and entity names now derive from device and area.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT HOME ASSISTANT USERS SAID ABOUT MARKETPLACE

The 2026.11 release thread on the project's own forum ran to more than twenty posts within the day. **Stefan Uytterhoeven** put the objection plainly: "*Why integrate hacs into core. Will you supervise the marketplace? I guess not.*" **Tom Carpenter** answered that the security model is unchanged — same warning, same source repository — and that what changed is the release cadence.

THE SCEPTIC · HOME ASSISTANT'S MARKETPLACE REMOVED THE FRICTION, NOT THE RISK

Uytterhoeven's objection is the real one, and the 2026.11 release notes do not answer it. Marketplace's own first-run notice says community projects are not tested, audited or supported by the project — yet they install from a menu between Apps and Dashboards in core settings. The friction that signalled *you are leaving the supported product* is gone; the liability has not moved. Carpenter's reply is technically correct, and that is the difficulty: nothing improved except discoverability. **What would settle it:** six months without a malicious Marketplace integration, and a measurable fall in breakage.[3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

llama.cpp tagged v0.9.0 on 4 November, adding an eight-bit floating-point quantisation type and support for Mistral's new trillion-parameter model, plus offline transcription in forty languages with speaker attribution.[4]

The multi-node tensor-parallelism patch this desk flagged on 4 November merged on 3 November and is now in a tagged release — 1,348 tokens a second of prefill and 23.5 of generation across two machines, against 847 and 13.0 on one.[4]

SOURCES 1 The Home Assistant 2026.11 release post of 4 November 2026, read at source: the integration count, the Marketplace migration terms, the Matter camera support, the Zigbee and LoRaWAN additions, the quality-scale movement and the 44 sections of breaking changes. **The post states no contributor count and no performance figures, and none is invented here.** 2 The author's own pinned issue on the add-on project's repository, opened 16 October 2026 and read at source; the thread is locked to collaborators. 3 The project's community forum thread of 4 November 2026, read at source, handles and display names as shown. **Reddit refused this desk entirely, so no Reddit sentiment appears on this page.** 4 The llama.cpp v0.9.0 release notes and pull request 28967, and the vLLM v0.33.0 release notes, all read at source. **The speed-up figures are the contributor's own: the project's founder could not reproduce them on his own pair of machines and a second maintainer matched them only after forcing both to the same clock.**

THE KIT · DELL'S GOOGLEBOOK

Engadget scores Dell's $999 Googlebook 6.5 and recommends the Windows version

Devindra Hardawar measured 15 hours 15 minutes of battery on 2 November, and found one app draining half the charge while idle in the background.

Dell's thinnest and best-made small laptop in years went on sale last month running neither Windows nor Apple's system, but Google's — and on Monday 2 November the first full review of it landed. The verdict: the machine is lovely, the software is not finished. It scored **6.5 out of 10**, and the reviewer told readers to buy the Windows version of the same laptop, at the same **$999**.[1]

The stakes are bigger than one laptop. Google spent a year merging the software that runs its phones with the software that ran its cheap school laptops, relaunched the result at the premium end this autumn, and is now attacking ground Microsoft and Apple have held for thirty years. The test every reviewer has applied is the same one: can a laptop built on phone software run the programs people actually buy laptops for.[1]

What the hardware is: a **Snapdragon X Elite** of twelve cores to 4.0GHz, a 13.4-inch touchscreen at 2560 by 1600 and 30 to 120Hz, 500 nits, a 52-watt-hour battery, **1kg**, in a colour Dell calls Shimmer — and two USB-C ports, no card reader, no headphone socket. The ladder runs **$999.99** for 16GB and 512GB, **$1,599.99** for 32GB, **$1,799.99** with a terabyte. Google requires at least 16GB on any machine in the programme. The platform itself launched on 4 October in America and a day later in Britain, Ireland, France, Germany, Canada and Australia.[2]

And the measurements cut both ways. Hardawar recorded **15 hours 15 minutes** in a standard battery test against Dell's claim of up to sixteen — the best of the three machines of this kind reviewed so far. He also recorded a fault: one video app drained **half the battery in an hour** while sitting idle in the background. His listed complaints are about the system, not the laptop: half-baked, few compatible desktop applications, phone apps unpleasant to use, phone syncing useless.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THREE REVIEWERS SAID ABOUT GOOGLEBOOKS

Devindra Hardawar of Engadget would "*go so far as to say the entire Googlebook concept is a failure*", while calling the hardware "*once again among the best in the PC world*". **Ben Schoon** at 9to5Google, on the HP at $1,119: "*a young and incapable operating system*" with "*an incredibly limited library of desktop-class software*" — "*I cannot recommend that anyone invests $1,200 into a Googlebook.*" **Sam Rutherford**, the kindest at 7.9 out of 10 for Lenovo's $1,099 machine, still says it is "*best to revisit this platform once more of its initial kinks have been ironed out*".[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE GOOGLEBOOK MAY NOT BE A FAILURE

Rutherford's own numbers argue against Hardawar's verdict. The same system on Intel silicon scored **9,011** in a multi-core benchmark against **7,124** for a comparable Windows machine — the platform is not slow. Dell's is the Arm machine, where the missing-applications complaint is partly a translation problem that narrowed on Windows for Arm as developers shipped native builds. And the battery figure cuts the other way: Dell's 15 hours 15 minutes against the Lenovo's 8 hours 30. **What would settle it:** whether the count of desktop-class applications has grown materially by Google's first annual update. If it has not, Hardawar is right.[3]

50%

OF THE BATTERY DRAINED IN ONE HOUR BY A SINGLE APP SITTING IDLE IN THE BACKGROUND[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Canva shipped Affinity for iPad on 2 November with photo editing, vector design and page layout in one application, and its core tools free.[4]

Adobe added licensed Universal and Warner music to Premiere on mobile on 3 November.[4]

Ricoh confirmed on 2 November that its GR Space gallery comes to New York this winter — the camera brand's own room, not a dealer counter.[4]

SOURCES 1 Engadget's review of 2 November 2026 by Devindra Hardawar, read at source: the score, the battery measurement, the idle-drain fault, the verdict and the listed complaints. 2 Dell's own configurator and product page for model DX13267, read at source, for the processor, display, battery, weight, ports and all three prices; the platform launch dates from a public encyclopaedia record. **A reported Google price of $1,199 at announcement, against Dell's $999.99 at launch, appears on one aggregator only and is not printed as a figure here.** 3 Engadget's Lenovo review of 30 October 2026 by Sam Rutherford, with its benchmark and battery figures, and 9to5Google's HP review of 16 October 2026 by Ben Schoon, both read at source. **Reddit and The Verge both refused this desk, so no forum sentiment appears on this page.** 4 DPReview, 2 and 3 November 2026, read at source.

THE GOOD LIFE · AUDIO-TECHNICA'S WOODEN FLAGSHIP

Audio-Technica prices its Kiso-cypress flagship headphone at 3,799 US dollars

It debuted at the Paris Audio Video Show on 23 October and now sits above the firm's own open-backed model at $3,499 — the sealed one is the dearer.

Audio-Technica has put a price of 3,799 US dollars on the most expensive headphone it has ever built, a sealed, cabled pair whose earcups are turned from Kiso cypress — the timber Japan reserves for Shinto shrines and temples — and hand-finished in Echizen lacquer, a craft the company dates back more than fifteen hundred years. It went on sale after a debut at the Paris Audio Video Show on 23 October.[1]

The sealing is the point. A closed headphone shuts its earcups against the outside, so nothing leaks out to the passenger beside you and nothing leaks in — which is the only format that works on a night flight. The usual price of that seal is muddied bass, because the trapped air behind the driver pushes back. Audio-Technica's claim — and it is only the company's — is that it has engineered that air out of the problem.[1]

The specification, for the record: the ATH-AWX7000 runs a new 58mm hybrid diaphragm of polymer film bonded to a metal dome, at 48 ohms and 97 decibels per milliwatt, 5Hz to 50kHz, 353 grams without a cable, 1,000mW maximum input. The frame is magnesium in a navy called *kachi-iro*, the sliders machined aluminium, the headband and pads Japanese deerskin. Two braided cables ship with it, balanced and unbalanced, in a hard case. It is built in Tokyo.[2]

And the oddity in the line-up is the price ladder. The open-backed **ATH-ADX7000** is **$3,499**, so Audio-Technica has made its closed flagship the costlier of the pair — an inversion of the usual order, where the open design is the audiophile object and the closed one the compromise you take travelling.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT REVIEWERS SAID ABOUT AUDIO-TECHNICA'S $3,799 FLAGSHIP

Nobody has measured the Kiso-cypress headphone yet, and the people who have heard it say so. **Delaney Czernikowski** of Audio46, who has heard it, calls it "*a great headphone for those looking for their next closed-back upgrade*" and "*good for analytical listening*" — but warns that "*for people sensitive to bass, you may find the AWX7000 to be a bit overwhelming*". **Stefan Schickedanz** of STEREO GUIDE filed it deliberately as news rather than review, attributing the transient claims to the manufacturer. **April Ossington** at ChannelNews wrote that the bass, dynamics and soundstage claims "*still need listening tests to verify*".[3]

THE SCEPTIC · AUDIO-TECHNICA'S $3,799 HEADPHONE HAS NO PUBLISHED MEASUREMENT

Every performance claim on this page originates with the maker. Three of the four writers who have handled the headphone decline to vouch for the sound, and the one published listening impression flags the bass as possibly overwhelming — precisely the failure mode sealed headphones are notorious for, and precisely what the new chamber is sold as fixing. There is no published measurement set, and the cable socket is proprietary, so a replacement comes from one supplier. **What would settle it:** an independent frequency-response and distortion sweep showing the closed $3,799 model beats the open $3,499 one. None exists yet.[3]

353g

WITHOUT A CABLE — MAGNESIUM FRAME, DEERSKIN PADS, LACQUERED CYPRESS CUPS, BUILT IN TOKYO[2]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Phillips' Geneva Watch Auction XXIV runs 7 to 9 November with **220 lots**, headlined by a Cartier Portico mystery clock estimated at **1.8m to 3.6m Swiss francs**.[4]

Glashütte Original listed the Senator Aventurine Art Déco Blue at $40,400 and Girard-Perregaux the Laureato Fifty Three Gold Bridges at **$182,000**, both in the same 1 November round-up that carried the headphone.[4]

SOURCES 1 Gear Patrol, 23 October 2026 (Tucker Bowe) and its new-release round-up of 1 November 2026, read at source, for the price, the debut, the woods and the open-back comparison. **Audio-Technica's own product pages returned HTTP 403 to this desk in all three regions, so no figure here is quoted from the maker directly.** 2 Audio46's specification table and ecoustics' product listing, both read at source, 23 and 26 October 2026, for the driver, impedance, sensitivity, weight, cables and case. 3 Audio46 (Delaney Czernikowski), STEREO GUIDE (Stefan Schickedanz) and ChannelNews Australia (April Ossington), 23–26 October 2026. **Head-Fi served a bot check and the headphone subreddit refused us, so no forum sentiment is claimed anywhere on this page.** 4 Gear Patrol's watch and release round-ups of 1 November 2026 and JCK Online on the Phillips sale. **A UK price of about £3,300 appears in one headline only and is not printed here as a figure.**

SCREEN & SOUND · THE BLACK PARADE AT TWENTY

My Chemical Romance tops the Billboard 200 twenty years after The Black Parade

Luminate counted 78,000 equivalent album units on the Billboard chart dated 7 November, up 653 per cent, as the reissue jumped from No. 139 to No. 1.

My Chemical Romance reached number one on the American album chart for the first time on 1 November, with a record released in October 2006. The twentieth-anniversary reissue of *The Black Parade* moved from 139th place to first in a single week, on 78,000 equivalent album units.[1]

The gap is the news. Billboard counts in a blended currency — copies sold, downloads, and streams converted at a fixed rate into one number it calls an equivalent album unit — and on that measure a twenty-year-old album has just beaten everything released this year. Billboard records it as the longest wait between a release and a first week at number one, ahead of Toby Keith's 35 *Biggest Hits*, which took nearly sixteen years and arrived after his death.[1]

How it was done is on the receipt. Of the 78,000 units, **68,000 were pure album sales**, up **2,082 per cent** on the week, across **twenty physical variants** with six bonus tracks. The band had just closed a five-night sold-out residency at the Hollywood Bowl on Halloween. It displaced Olivia Rodrigo, whose *you seem pretty sad for a girl so in love* had led the previous chart on 75,000 units. The reissue also gave the band a first British number one, and the original album has been certified four-times platinum.[2]

In 2006 the same record sold **240,000 copies** in its first week and finished second, behind the *Hannah Montana* soundtrack's 281,000. Which is the figure worth holding beside this week's: the album needed less than a third of its losing 2006 number to win in 2026.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHY THE BLACK PARADE WON NOW

Paige Owens, author of 500 *Essential Emo Albums*, on the 2006 defeat: "*It's hard to go up against that type of a dedicated fan base, for Miley (Cyrus), Disney and pop music*" — and on the anniversary tour, that it is "*expanding the lore and conceptualization behind the record*". **Jason Pettigrew**, formerly editor-in-chief of *Alternative Press*: "*They made the big gestures*", and the reissue's extra tracks were "*recontextualized with something remarkably contemporary*". **Ben Gibbard** of Death Cab for Cutie: "*I'm a firm believer in the idea that if something is new to you, it is new.*"[1]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE BLACK PARADE'S 78,000 UNITS MEASURE

Strip the variants and the chart position goes. Sixty-eight of the 78,000 units were physical copies sold across twenty different editions of the same album to a fanbase that collects them — a mechanic the chart rewards and the music does not require. On streaming alone the record was sitting in the triple digits a week earlier, and nothing about the recording changed. One outlet called the result a debut; the chart shows a move from 139 to 1, which is a different claim about a different thing. **What would settle it:** Billboard publishing the streaming-only rank for the same week. It does not.[2]

2,082%

THE WEEK-ON-WEEK RISE IN PURE ALBUM SALES OF *THE BLACK PARADE*, ACROSS TWENTY PHYSICAL VARIANTS[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

The American weekend box office of 30 October to 1 November took $62,028,639 across 65 titles, led by *You Can See Everything* on **$11,445,628**, down 39 per cent in 3,243 theatres.[3]

***Clayface* fell 54.2 per cent in its second weekend to $11,002,116**, for a running total of **$44,666,368**.[3]

BTS's São Paulo concert film opened sixth on about $2.8m, and *Resident Evil* passed **$157,424,459** domestically.[3]

SOURCES 1 The Associated Press, 2 November 2026 (Maria Sherman), read at source: the unit counts, the Luminate percentages, the 2006 comparison and all three interview quotes. **Billboard's own site returned HTTP 402 to this desk, so its record-keeping claim reaches this page through the AP and is flagged as relayed.** 2 The Official Charts Company's Billboard 200 listing for the chart dated 7 November 2026, read at source for the 139-to-1 move and the 162 weeks on chart; Consequence, 2 November 2026, for the British number one; The Music Universe, 1 November 2026, for the certification and the Hollywood Bowl residency. 3 The Numbers' weekend chart for 30 October to 1 November 2026 and Box Office Mojo's weekend 44 page, both read at source. **The BTS figure is a rounded estimate as published.**

THE FAMILY DESK · THE TEN O'CLOCK LINE

JAMA Pediatrics links late-night phone use to twenty minutes less teenage sleep

The study tracked 425 adolescents of mean age 14.8 across 7,591 nights of Fitbit sleep and phone-logged use, and reports confidence intervals throughout.

Teenagers who used their phones more than usual after ten at night slept about twenty minutes less that night and took roughly an hour longer to fall asleep, according to a study published online by JAMA Pediatrics on 19 October. General guidance for parents, not medical advice.[1]

What makes it worth reading is the design rather than the finding. Most research of this kind compares heavy phone users with light ones, and then inherits every other difference between those two sets of families. This one compared each child against their own average night, which removes the family from the comparison. The sleep was measured by a wrist tracker and the phone use recorded by the handset itself, not reported by the teenager the next morning. It remains an observation, not a proof of cause.[1]

The numbers, with their intervals, because this desk keeps asking for them and here they are. Per extra minute of use after ten, above that child's own average: sleep onset later by **0.87 minutes** (95% confidence interval 0.84 to 0.90), waking later by **0.37** (0.33 to 0.41), total sleep shorter by **0.43** (−0.47 to −0.39), all at **P<.001**. The sample was **425** adolescents inside a larger American brain cohort, half of them girls, over **7,591** person-nights collected between November 2020 and February 2024.[1]

Two details sharpen it. The effect grew steadily as the authors moved the cut-off from eight in the evening to midnight, so the clock is doing the work, not the daily dose. And use in the last five minutes before sleep added **0.74 minutes** of wakefulness afterwards (0.50 to 0.98). The authors' own recommendation names the hour: reduce use "*particularly after 10 pm*".[1]

THE CHATTER · SINGAPORE DREW THE SAME LATE-NIGHT PHONE LINE FIRST

Singapore's own rule on adolescent phone use and sleep predates this JAMA Pediatrics paper by a year, and lands on almost the same hour. From January 2026 secondary students must keep phones and smartwatches in lockers or bags for the whole school day, recess, activities and remedial included; the default "sleep hours" on government-issued student devices were pulled back from eleven at night to **half past ten**. The ministry's stated reason was displacement: "*Screen use among students has been shown to displace important activities such as sleep.*" That is the same mechanism this paper measured, set a year before it was published.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · TWENTY MINUTES, AND WHAT IT COSTS TO LOSE THEM

Read the per-minute estimate and the headline shrinks. Losing 0.43 minutes of sleep for every extra minute on the phone after ten means a child has to spend about **forty-six extra minutes** on it to lose the twenty. The intervals are narrow because there are 7,591 nights in the model, not because the effect is large. Reverse causation is untested and plausible: a child who cannot sleep reaches for the phone. **Candice Odgers** of the University of California, Irvine, has argued in *Nature* that causal claims in this field routinely outrun the evidence. **What would settle it:** a trial that moves the hour and measures the sleep.[3]

7,591

PERSON-NIGHTS OF WRIST-MEASURED SLEEP MATCHED TO PHONE-LOGGED USE — THE REASON THE INTERVALS ARE NARROW[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

The effect was monotonic across the evening. Moving the threshold later raised the estimate at every step — the strongest internal argument the paper makes.[1]

The data are older than the paper. Collection ended in February 2024 and the analysis ran from February to June 2026 — so the phones, apps and bedtime habits measured are those of 2021 to 2023.[1]

SOURCES 1 Zhao Y, Hale L, Christakis DA, "Evening Phone Use and Sleep Outcomes Among Youth", *JAMA Pediatrics*, published online 19 October 2026, doi:10.1001/jamapediatrics.2026.4902 — the abstract and results read at source on the journal's own system, including every confidence interval printed here. 2 The ministry's announcement of 30 November 2025, reaching this desk through a secondary report; **the ministry's own site returned empty bodies to repeated requests, so the quoted sentence is the only ministry wording available to us and the policy detail is single-sourced.** 3 Odgers C, "The great rewiring: is social media really behind an epidemic of teenage mental illness?", *Nature* 628(8006):29–30, 29 March 2024, doi:10.1038/d41586-024-00902-2; **Nature's own page redirected this desk to a login, so the citation is confirmed from a third-party record and no sentence of it is quoted.** The forty-six-minute figure is this desk's own division of the published estimate.

THE TWEEN YEARS · ICELAND'S SCHOOL PHONE BANS

Iceland's school phone bans did not improve adolescent mental health, JAMA finds

Twenty-two of Iceland's seventy schools banned phones between 2018 and 2023; across 23,938 students, bullying and social-media time did not move.

Banning phones across a whole school did not measurably improve its students' mental health, their friendships, the bullying they reported or the time they spent on social media, according to a study of every secondary school in Iceland published by JAMA Network Open on 27 October. General guidance for parents, not medical advice.[1]

This lands directly on a Singapore parent, because the policy a twelve-year-old here is living under started in January of this year. The method is the one economists use when they cannot run a trial: watch the schools that banned phones and those that did not, before and after, and call the difference between the two changes the effect. Its weakness is that both groups must have been moving in parallel beforehand. In Iceland they were not, and the authors say so.[1]

The results, with intervals. Depressive symptoms moved **0.65** (95% confidence interval 0.005 to 1.30, P=.05) — very slightly the wrong way. Mental well-being **−0.52** (−1.08 to 0.03), and for girls **−0.74** (−1.44 to −0.05, P=.04). Daily social-media use **0.10** (−0.08 to 0.28). A hurtful message carried an odds ratio of **0.93** (0.74 to 1.16), being teased by a group **1.28** (0.94 to 1.75). The authors set their threshold at **P<.002** for fifteen outcomes; nothing cleared it.[1]

The sample was **23,938** observations of mean age **13.98** across **70** schools, from the national youth survey of February 2016, February 2018 and November 2023. The authors' conclusion is narrower than the headlines it produced: bans alone "*may be insufficient to improve adolescent mental health at the population level*".[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT ICELAND'S NULL RESULT MET IN NORWAY

The contrast is the argument. Reporting the Icelandic null to parents, **Techlicious** set it against a Norwegian study that did find bans cut bullying and girls' mental-health consultations and lifted academic results — two Nordic countries, the same intervention, opposite findings. In Singapore the question was settled administratively: **Jasmin Lau**, Minister of State for Education, told Parliament in January that school offices can relay urgent messages, so students need no phone. **Candice Odgers** of the University of California, Irvine has argued the same point prospectively: a ban does not touch what is actually hurting adolescents.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY ICELAND'S BANS MAY LOOK WORSE THAN THEY WERE

The study's own table argues against its headline. Before any ban, girls in the schools that later banned phones were already improving faster — depressive symptoms **−2.50** (−3.27 to −1.73) and well-being **1.50** (0.96 to 2.04), both P<.001. When the trends are not parallel, the method pushes the post-policy estimate toward showing harm. The single follow-up wave was November 2023, five years after the earliest ban and months after the latest, and exposure is never modelled as a dose. **What would settle it:** a staggered-adoption design that tests the parallel trends, or Norway's opposite result replicated.[1]

0.93

ODDS RATIO FOR RECEIVING A HURTFUL MESSAGE AFTER A BAN (0.74–1.16) — NO MEASURABLE CHANGE[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Singapore's version is stricter than Iceland's was — lockers for the whole school day, not merely lesson time, so the Icelandic estimate measures a weaker treatment.[2]

Read both studies on this spread together. One finds the hour of use matters to a hundredth of a minute (p12); the other finds removing the phone for the school day changes nothing measurable. Both hold if the harm sits at bedtime, at home.[1]

SOURCES 1 Bonilla Aparicio E, Sigmarsdottir B, Haskell E, et al., "School Phone Bans and Adolescent Mental Health in Iceland", *JAMA Network Open* 2026;9(10):e2640893, published online 27 October 2026, doi:10.1001/jamanetworkopen.2026.40893 — the full article read at source on the journal's own system, including the pre-policy trend estimates and the Bonferroni threshold. 2 Techlicious, 28 October 2026, for the Norwegian comparison; the Singapore parliamentary answer of January 2026 through a secondary record, **because the ministry's site and the parliamentary record both refused this desk — single-sourced and flagged**; and Odgers's position as stated on American public radio on 26 June 2026, **whose transcript carries no verbatim quotation, so her argument is paraphrased and not quoted.**

THE MACRO DESK · THE WAR PREMIUM DEFLATING

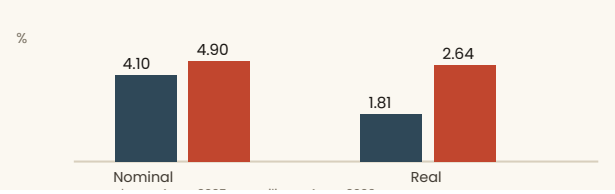
Democrats win both chambers, and traders cut Brent eight per cent to $95

Brent settled near $95.06 on 4 November after $113.39 on 30 October , sixteen per cent off in three sessions, while gold rose 3.4 per cent and the US ten-year fell five basis points.

American voters handed the Democrats both the House and the Senate on Tuesday 3 November, and by Wednesday's close traders had taken eight per cent off the price of oil, pulled the American ten-year government bond yield down to **4.90 per cent** and pushed gold up **3.4 per cent** to about **$4,066**. Every asset in a globally diversified portfolio repriced off one judgement. Market explanation, not advice.[1]

The judgement is about war. The eight-month conflict between the United States and Iran has driven both inflation and high bond yields all year, and a divided Washington is read as making further war spending, and further war, less likely. Oil feeds prices, which feed what lenders demand, which sets the discount rate under every share and bond on earth. Nothing about the war changed this week; the estimate of its future did.[2]

Name the regime: **the war premium deflating**. The dominant force on a global equity-and-bond portfolio is the oil-and-fiscal risk premium in the long end, not central-bank policy — a thirty-year at **5.28 per cent** over a ten-year at **4.90** and a two-year at **4.58** is a steep, supply-driven curve. The equity–bond correlation is positive, and on Wednesday it helped: global equities up **1.36 per cent** and the bond proxy up **0.33** together. But the same positive correlation removed the hedge on the way down. The help is directional, not structural.[1]



The ten-year rose **80 basis points** in a year; the real yield rose **83**, so expected inflation fell three. *Meridian* original, from the Treasury's own daily par and real yield curves.[1]

THE LEVELS · WEDNESDAY 4 NOVEMBER

VWRA[1]	$190.64	▲ 1.36%
US 10-year[1]	4.90%	▼ 5bp
Brent[2]	$95.06	▼ 8.2%
Bitcoin	$80,216	▲ 3.7%
USD/SGD	1.2788	▼ 0.19%

Gold and bitcoin are evening spot reads, not exchange closes. Not advice.

THE VERDICT · WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD AND BITCOIN

VWRA — a breadth rally, not a technology one: the Dow rose 3.03 per cent to 53,356.12 and the S&P 1.58 to 7,688.62 while the semiconductor index *fell* 3.13 to 10,268.65. It is still 5.8 per cent below its year high. **Global bonds** — the proxy sits in the lower half of its 5.571 to 6.151 range, and since the whole rise in yields has been real, duration only pays if the real rate falls. **Gold** — a 3.4 per cent bounce inside a round trip from $5,586 in January to $3,879 in October. **Bitcoin** — $80,216 against a year high of $107,428, trading this week as a high-beta risk asset, not a hedge.

THE SCEPTIC · WHY BRENT AT $95 MAY BE POSITIONING, NOT PEACE

The de-escalation has not happened. Ryan McKay of TD Securities says headlines alone will not strip the premium "*so long as there is no concrete conclusion to the war, and tanker and Houthi attacks remain prevalent*". The evidence is with him: Iran says it will not accept diplomacy under coercion, Britain's maritime trade operations centre has logged at least four attacks on shipping since 1 November, and American officials put a strike on Qeshm Island on Monday. **What would settle it:** Brent back above $110 on one headline.[2]

16.69

THE VOLATILITY INDEX, DOWN 19.9 PER CENT IN A DAY AS THE DOW ADDED 1,569 POINTS[1]

WAR PREMIUM DEFLATING · STEEP CURVE · RISK-ON

SOURCES 1 The United States Treasury's own daily par and real yield curves for 4 November 2026 and 4 November 2025, read directly as published data, supply all four yield figures and the chart; every market level read instrument by instrument from exchange and index data on the evening of 4 November 2026. **The Monetary Authority of Singapore's own daily rate service refused this desk, so the Singapore dollar cross is a market read, not the official fixing.** 2 CNBC, 2 and 3 November 2026, for the Brent settlements and the Qeshm report; Oilprice, 3 November, for the Kpler and Phillip Nova comments and the surplus figures. **The 30 October level is implied from the published percentage moves, not a settlement this desk read.** 3 BondBloxx and the BlackRock Investment Institute's weekly of 2 November 2026, read at source. **Bloomberg, the Associated Press and both Singapore business dailies refused this desk; Reddit and Bogleheads were unreachable, so no retail-investor sentiment is reported.** This desk explains markets and does not advise.

THE INVITATION · COMPETITIVE DOG AGILITY

Elsa Soo of Singapore, aged 60, finished fifth in the world at Turku

The Singapore Kennel Club has run 79 trials under international rules and 215 under its own. One May trial produced three qualifying rounds out of thirty-one.

Competitive dog agility is one person and one dog running a numbered course of jumps, tunnels and weave poles against a clock, and this page is about what it actually is and who does it. The dog runs off-lead. The handler touches nothing, and steers by voice and body alone. Fastest clear round wins.[1]

What makes it hard is that nobody sees the course before the day. Under international rules the ring is at least twenty metres by forty, the course a hundred to two hundred and twenty metres with fifteen to twenty-two obstacles, at least seven of them jumps, and weave poles are compulsory on every course. The handler walks it on foot, without the dog, then runs it beside an animal who has never seen it. Dogs compete from fifteen months under American rules, eighteen under international ones.[1]

The scale is larger than the sport's obscurity suggests. In its thirty-first year, across the 2025 calendar, the American Kennel Club recorded **4,447 trials, 1,194,795 entries and 47,007 new titles**, of which **117 dogs** earned the highest championship. The United States Dog Agility Association, organised in 1986, counts **45,000-plus registered competitors**, 175 affiliated groups and more than a thousand days of events a year, with listed activity in Singapore, the Philippines and Japan. In Britain, UK Agility International reports **14,000-plus members**.[2]

And the gateway is always the same story: a dog too clever for the flat. People arrive from an obedience class, do one tunnel, and the animal comes out of the far end transformed. The Singapore version of this has a face. **Elsa Soo**, sixty years old, a retired narcotics-dog handler from the prison service, placed **fifth in the world** in the individual intermediate class at the world championship in Turku, Finland, in September — and she is blunt about how: "*I am 60 years old, I have bad legs, and I cannot suddenly make myself run like a 25-year-old handler*," so she "*had to find another way*".[3]

> ***"I am 60 years old, I have bad legs, and I cannot suddenly make myself run like a 25-year-old handler."***

THE CHATTER · THE FOUR SCHOOLS ELSA SOO COMPETES AGAINST

Four houses teach competitive agility, and they teach against each other. Steve Schwarz writes AgilityNerd, twenty years of posts plus a free toolchain — course design, title tracking, jump-height lookups — and is the sport's engineer-in-residence. **Bad Dog Agility**, run by Sarah, Jennifer and Esteban Fernandez-Lopez out of Houston, has 250-plus podcast episodes, 1.3 million downloads and the sport's ranking lists. **Silvia Trkman** of Slovenia, three times a world champion with two different dogs, is the patron saint of running contacts and of training tricks first. **Susan Garrett** teaches the stopped contact and a weave method so dominant that the retailers write their product copy around it.[4]

3 of 31

RUNS THAT QUALIFIED AT ONE SINGAPORE TITLING TRIAL IN MAY — THE SPORT, HONESTLY RENDERED[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT AGILITY'S ENTRY NUMBERS HIDE

The qualifying rate is the number nobody advertises. This desk read the full results of the Singapore Kennel Club's seventy-eighth trial under international rules, held at Punggol on 1 May 2026: roughly **thirty-one runs** across three levels and four height groups, and **three qualifying rounds in the whole meeting**. That is the sport, honestly rendered — and it is also why the American figure of 1.19 million entries should be read as attempts, not achievements. Against it, the club has now run **79 international-rule trials and 215 under its own**, which is a small scene but an old and serious one. **What would settle the scale question:** a published count of active Singapore handlers. The club does not publish one.[5]

SOURCES 1 The international federation's own agility regulations, approved May 2025 and amended February 2026, read at source as published: ring and course dimensions, obstacle counts, the compulsory weaves and the minimum ages. 2 The American Kennel Club's own year-end statistics for 2025, published February 2026; the United States Dog Agility Association's and UK Agility International's own membership pages, all read at source. 3 VnExpress International, 4 November 2026, reporting Soo's placing and quoting her directly; the placing cross-checked against the championship's own published results. 4 Each author's own site, read at source: AgilityNerd, Bad Dog Agility, Silvia Trkman's school and Susan Garrett's. 5 The Singapore Kennel Club's own published results for its 78th international-rule titling trial, 1 May 2026, counted run by run by this desk; the trial totals from the club's own record. **Reddit is blocked to this desk entirely, so no subscriber count and no forum thread is quoted anywhere in these three pages.**

THE DEEP END · AGILITY'S EQUIPMENT BILL

Clip and Go quotes $6,900 for three agility obstacles and ten weeks

Freight adds $845 to a residential address on a 150-inch pallet, and Galican, which supplied the 2026 world championship in Turku, publishes no prices.

Agility's gear divides at one line, and this page is about where that line falls: everything a person can own, and the three obstacles they probably should not. Jumps, tunnels and weave poles are the practicable half. The A-frame, the dogwalk and the seesaw — the three with a painted contact zone a paw must touch — are the half that costs a car.[1]

Start with what the cheap tier is for. Plastic sets and a ten-foot tunnel with sandbags at about **$80** will teach a dog to go through a thing; the uprights blow over, the poles are not spaced to specification, and none of it is legal in a ring. That is the whole of what this desk will say about it, because the mid tier is where a serious home setup actually lives.[1]

The mid tier, from the two American retailers that define the category. A heavyweight ten-foot tunnel at the wider rib spacing is **$259.99**, fifteen foot **$339.99**; at the tighter international spacing, **$389.95** for ten feet and **$579.99** for twenty. Tunnel bags run **$49.99** to **$74.99** a pair, and a tunnel mover is **$164.99**. Weave poles are the real decision: a pair-by-pair training set runs **$171.99** to **$599.99** and the method wants three sets, channel weaves **$539.99** to **$849.99**, a twelve-pole bundle **$819.99**, and a plain metal-base twelve at **$299.99**. A practice seesaw is **$199.99**, uprights from **$7.99**.[1]

Then the high tier, where the lead time is the story and the vendors say so in print. Competition contacts from the Michigan maker run **$2,900 to $3,745** for a dogwalk, **$2,999 to $3,744** for an A-frame, **$1,300 to $2,000** for a seesaw, or **$6,900 to $8,340** for all three — aluminium planks, wet-pour rubber, locking swivel wheels, adjustable from thirty to forty-eight inches — above the notice that buyers should "*allow 8-10 weeks for delivery*". Freight adds **$720** commercially or **$845** to a house, on a pallet 150 inches long and 220 pounds heavy that needs two people to receive. A rival's seven-foot A-frame is **$1,515** at six to eight weeks; its adjustable dogwalk **$1,470 to $2,031.75**. A full British aluminium set is **£5,995**.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHO BUILDS AGILITY EQUIPMENT TO ORDER

The custom tier here is a phone call, not a cart. In the English Midlands, **Tim and Ruth Ryder** list an A-frame at **£210**, a three-section dogwalk at **£225** and a seesaw at **£150**, "*made to order, painted in the colours you request… to any specifications you require, perhaps for garden use?*" **Park Farm Agility** handcrafts pressure-treated timber to bespoke heights and talks the buyer through their space before taking the order. Neither publishes a lead time or a deposit. At the top, **M.A.D. Agility** — Mark and Jen Dreese, thirty years, American-made — supplies world-team arenas, and **Galican** of Galicia supplied the 2026 world championship in Turku, its ninth, while every item on its site reads "*Price via your distributor.*"[3]

$845

RESIDENTIAL FREIGHT ON ONE DOGWALK — A 150-INCH PALLET, 220 POUNDS, TWO PEOPLE TO UNLOAD[2]

THE SCEPTIC · THE AGILITY FIELD THAT COSTS MORE THAN THE OBSTACLES

Spend $6,900 on three obstacles and you still have nowhere legal to put them. The best-documented home training field in the sport is a blog post that ends in a concession. Steve Schwarz itemised his own: an eighty-by-twenty-foot strip, four inches of playground mulch over weed barrier, about **$3,000** of tree removal and stump grinding and **$5,000** of site work. He rejected artificial turf at a **$25,000** quote and compacted limestone at $4,000 as too hard to jump on. His verdict on what he built: the mulch **is not stable enough to jump at speed** — contacts, tunnels and weaves only. A genuinely regulation ring is twenty by forty metres, about 8,600 square feet, and pet turf runs eight to eighteen dollars a foot installed. That is a six-figure lawn. **What would settle it:** a published surface specification anyone can build to. There is not one.[4]

SOURCES 1 Clean Run's and J&J Dog Supplies' own product pages, read at source November 2026, for every mid-tier price and the entry-tier tunnel. 2 The maker's competition-contact listings and the retailer's freight schedule, read at source, including the delivery notice quoted; the rival A-frame and dogwalk prices and lead time from that maker's own pages; the British set price from its maker's own listing. **The flagship dogwalk listing carries no customer reviews at all.** 3 Agilitynet's small-maker listings for the Midlands prices; each workshop's own page; the championship's own supplier credit and the supplier's own price policy, read at source. 4 Steve Schwarz's own account of building his practice area, 15 March 2020, read at source, for every figure and the concession; the ring dimensions from the federation's regulations and turf costs from current installation guides. **Prices are listed in the currency each vendor quotes and are not converted.**

THE DEEP END · AGILITY'S INJURY NUMBERS

Eight kennel bodies back CARIS, which counts 2.10 dogwalk incidents per thousand runs

The CARIS coalition watched 320,000 dogwalk runs across 1,385 trials; 91.5 per cent of incidents showed no apparent injury, and none needed a vet that day.

Agility's own safety argument used to run on survey recall, and this page is about the year it started running on counted observations instead. Ask handlers to remember, and 41.4 per cent of 4,197 dogs had been out of the sport for over a week with an injury. Watch the runs as they happen, and the picture is far calmer.[1]

Which is the genuinely new thing in this sport in 2026 — not a piece of equipment but a measurement. Between April and November 2025 a coalition called CARIS — eight rival sanctioning bodies co-operating for the first time — collected judge-reported data from **1,385 trials**: **320,000** dogwalk, **340,000** seesaw and **418,000** A-frame performances, and **1,193** incident reports.[2]

The rates: **2.10** incidents per thousand runs on the dogwalk, **1.04** on the seesaw, **0.40** on the A-frame. Of those, **91.5 per cent** showed no apparent injury and the dog finished the run; under one per cent showed apparent injury, and **none required immediate veterinary transport**. Injuries per thousand runs work out at about **0.03** on the dogwalk. **Dr Arielle Pechette Markley** and **Dr Abigail Shoben** put it precisely: "*The dogwalk is not uniquely dangerous, but it is uniquely demanding*", and "*frequency of events and severity of concern are not always aligned.*" Their own caution: the findings are "*descriptive and foundational, not definitive*".[2]

The year's other measurement is about speed. In April **1,844,372** qualifying American jumping runs by **35,540** dogs between 2012 and 2024 were analysed: average speed rose by about **2.6 seconds** over a 160-yard course, and the fastest runs got faster fastest — while entries in the lower-jump, longer-time division grew from about **14 to 34 per cent** and competing dogs *declined*. Quicker at the top, smaller and more cautious underneath. The authors make no claim that speed causes injury.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT HELSINKI COUNTED THAT CARIS DID NOT

Helsinki counted the dogwalk falls CARIS's judges never saw, because they happen in training. Leena Inkilä and **Anna Boström**, from 1,835 responses covering 1,603 dogs, record **2.6 falls and 0.6 injuries per thousand** dogwalk performances, with **nearly 90 per cent of both happening in training rather than competition**, and — settling the oldest argument in the sport — **no difference between running and stopped contacts**. Their framing: "*Every dogwalk performance carries a risk of falling.*" The money pits are plainer: contacts bought before a coach, $845 of freight, $25,000 of turf, and the governing body's cut per run rising to **$4.50** in January.[4]

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS, IN SINGAPORE

Spend nothing for a month, then pay a coach rather than a maker: a weekend camp is **S$380**, six basic sessions **S$1,100**, six advanced **S$1,500**. Kennel-club membership comes next, with separate record books for the club's rules and the international ones, and trials about five weekends a year at an 8,000-square-foot indoor hall in Punggol — the sport's precondition here, since local guidance is to train before nine or after seven for the heat.[5]

NEXT DESCENTS · VOTE FOR TOMORROW'S RABBIT HOLE

Foraging & wild food — identification as a discipline, the legal grey zones, and a near-free hobby with a hard failure mode.

Origami & paper craft — the mathematics underneath it, the paper people import, and the folders who publish proofs.

SDR & signal hunting — a thirty-dollar receiver, the whole spectrum, and a community that identifies noises for sport.

SOURCES 1 Sundby, Pechette Markley, Shoben and Kieves, *Frontiers in Veterinary Science* 9:869702 (2022), an internet survey of 4,197 dogs, read at source; earlier surveys by Markley and colleagues (2021) and Cullen and colleagues (2013) give 41.7 and about 32 per cent. 2 The Canine Sports Science Consortium's own research update on the CARIS data, read at source, for the participating bodies, the trial and observation counts, every rate and both quotations; the researchers also appeared on the sport's podcast in April 2026. 3 McCormack-Mager, Pechette Markley, Fernandezlopez and Shoben, *Frontiers in Veterinary Science*, published 10 April 2026, read at source. 4 Inkilä and Boström, University of Helsinki, their own research summary read at source; the fee change from the governing body's own 2026 insert and the club premium lists that reprint it. 5 Two Singapore schools' own published price lists, the kennel club's own rules and trial record, the training hall's own booking page, and local heat guidance reviewed 6 July 2026 — all read at source. **Facebook groups and channel subscriber counts were not read and no such number appears here.**

FITNESS · THE ANTIOXIDANT THAT BACKFIRED

Copenhagen's Fabian Finger finds an antioxidant worsened muscle loss in mice

Fabian Finger's Nature Aging paper of 29 September restored one mitochondrial fat from 27 to 67 per cent of normal and reversed the wasting.

A **University of Copenhagen team reports that the drift from fast muscle to slow muscle in ageing is not simple decay but a deliberate trade** — and that mopping up the molecules driving it with a common antioxidant supplement made the animals' muscles worse over eight weeks, not better. General guidance, not medical advice.[1]

This matters because the longevity shelf is stacked with antioxidants. The molecules they promise to neutralise are the reactive by-products of the cell's own power plants; here those by-products turn out to be a signal the muscle is using on purpose. The other term the paper leans on is a fat found only in the inner wall of those power plants, which falls with age in mice and in human muscle alike. Take away the signal and you take away the adaptation.[1]

The mechanism, stated plainly. Lowering **cardiolipin** in young mice reproduced ageing: the fast-to-slow fibre shift, structural abnormalities in the mitochondria, loss of function. Restoring it from **27 to 67 per cent** of normal reversed the wasting. Mice born without muscle cardiolipin died at about **four months**; adults in whom it was switched off lost grip strength within **five weeks**. The low-cardiolipin animals took up more glucose and routed it to making antioxidants rather than energy.[1]

The comparison for a reader in his forties comes from elsewhere, and it is sobering in a useful way. A Karolinska cohort of **427** Swedes born in 1958, followed from age sixteen to sixty-three, puts the peak of aerobic capacity at **26 to 36**, declining **0.3 to 0.6 per cent a year** and accelerating to **2.0 to 2.5**, for a fall of **30 to 48 per cent** by sixty-three. Muscle power peaks earlier: twenty-seven in men. Taking up exercise in adulthood was associated with better results on every measure.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE COPENHAGEN AUTHORS SAY THE FIBRE SWITCH IS

Fabian Finger, the paper's first author: "*The fiber switch is not the muscle failing, but the muscle trading power for protection*" — and "*that's also why interfering with it can backfire.*" **Zachary Gerhart-Hines**, the senior author, on the rescue: "*What encourages me most is that even a partial recovery of cardiolipin was enough to bring the muscle back.*" The paper's own language calls the remodelling "*an active, adaptive response protecting cellular integrity*". Of the outlets that covered it, one published a line-by-line methods audit rather than a summary — which is where the next box comes from.[1]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT FINGER'S ANTIOXIDANT RESULT DOES NOT SHOW

These are mice, in a severe model. The engineered knockout lowered cardiolipin far further than ordinary ageing does. The human side is **nine reanalysed muscle samples** — four donors aged 22 to 35, five aged 53 to 69 — — and the methods say men only while the reporting summary says both sexes. The methods also state the animals were not randomly assigned and the analysis was not blinded, which that summary contradicts; most comparisons ran on fewer than a dozen animals with **no confidence intervals, no p-values and no effect sizes** published. The adult rescue did not test cardiolipin as a treatment, and high-dose antioxidant can disturb insulin signalling on its own, so that arm is confounded. **What would settle it:** a human trial where antioxidant around training does not blunt strength.[3]

27 → 67%

CARDIOLIPIN RESTORED AS A SHARE OF NORMAL — ENOUGH TO REVERSE THE WASTING[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Penn State's randomised trial of four exercises for four minutes a day — 97 adults of mean age 74, twelve weeks, **81 per cent** adherence — added **4.2** chair stands in thirty seconds and **3.6 seconds** of single-leg balance. No effect sizes or intervals in the public account.[4]

SOURCES 1 Finger F, et al., "Mitochondrial membrane lipid cardiolipin controls fiber-type adaptations in aging muscle via estrogen-related receptor γ", *Nature Aging* 2026;6(10):2092, published online 29 September 2026, doi:10.1038/s43587-026-01227-7. **Nature's own page redirects this desk to a login, so the figures and both authors' quotations are taken from the institutional and science-press accounts of 29 September and 27–28 October 2026, read at source.** 2 Westerståhl M, et al., *Journal of Cachexia, Sarcopenia and Muscle* 2025;16(6):e70134, doi:10.1002/jcsm.70134, n=427, trial registration NCT06496204, read through Europe PMC. **The abstract reports no confidence intervals.** 3 The published methods audit of 5 October 2026, read at source, for the sample sizes, the randomisation and blinding contradictions, the sex discrepancy and the conflict disclosure. 4 Science news releases of 14, 20 and 21 October 2026, read at source; the Penn State trial is PLOS One 2026;21(3):e0336748.

THE DIARY · A SECOND NIGHT ADDED

Kenshi Yonezu adds a second Singapore night on 30 January

The extra date went up on 22 October, and Singapore is the GHOST tour's only South-East Asian stop. In Tokyo, a centenary Orsay show opens 14 November with every visitor under 18 free.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

13–15 Nov — **Muara Festival 2026 · Era Dance Theatre**
ESPLANADE — THEATRES ON THE BAY · **NO PRICES PUBLISHED ON THE LISTING** · DANCE, SUITABLE FOR TWELVE[1]

28–29 Nov — **BABYMONSTER · World Tour [괜 CHOOM]**
PROMOTER-LISTED, ON SALE · **VENUE NOT RE-CONFIRMED ON THIS READ** — THE PROMOTER'S PAGE GIVES DATES ONLY[2]

3–6 Dec — **Voices · A Festival of Song 2026**
ESPLANADE · CHORAL, A CAPPELLA, MUSICAL THEATRE AND OPERA · **PRICES NOT PUBLISHED**; THE FESTIVAL HABITUALLY CARRIES FREE PROGRAMMES[1]

23 JAN — **Young K of DAY6 · <YOUNGEST> solo tour**
PROMOTER-LISTED · NO PRICE BAND PUBLISHED[2]

29–30 Jan — ★ **Kenshi Yonezu · GHOST world tour**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · **THE 30 JANUARY NIGHT WAS ADDED ON 22 OCTOBER** · THE TOUR'S ONLY SOUTH-EAST ASIAN CITY · **NO PRICES ON THE ARTIST'S OWN PAGE**[3]

14 FEB — **Freya Skye · Stars Align Tour**
PROMOTER-LISTED · NO PRICE PUBLISHED[2]

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

21–22 Nov — ★ **High-End Audio & Accessory Show 2026**
HULIC HALL, ASAKUSABASHI, TOKYO · **FREE ADMISSION** · BOWERS & WILKINS SHOWING THE 800 SERIES DIAMOND D5; LUMIN, REGA, DEVIALET, THORENS ALSO IN · **OFFICIAL HOURS STILL UNANNOUNCED**[4]

14 Nov–28 Mar — ★ **Masterworks from the Musée d'Orsay**
TOKYO METROPOLITAN ART MUSEUM, UENO, CENTENARY SHOW · ~110 WORKS · **¥2,400**, ADVANCE ¥2,200 · **EVERYONE 18 AND UNDER FREE** · CLOSED MONDAYS AND **22 DEC–3 JAN**[5]

10–31 Jan — **Australian Open 2027**
MELBOURNE PARK · **NO SALE DATES OR PRICES PUBLISHED** ON THE TOURNAMENT'S OWN SITE, WHICH LINKS OUT TO A TICKETING HOST THAT REFUSED THIS DESK[6]

25–28 Feb — ★ **CP+ 2027 · Pacifico Yokohama**
FREE, ADVANCE WEB REGISTRATION ONLY — OPENING "EARLY DECEMBER" · 25 FEBRUARY IS PRESS AND TRADE UNTIL NOON · **THE ORGANISER SAYS CP+ WILL BECOME THE CAMERA & IMAGING SHOW**[7]

7 MAR — **Tokyo Marathon 2027**
ENTRY IS CLOSED — THE LOTTERY DREW ON 11 SEPTEMBER AND CHARITY PLACES ARE GONE · SPECTATING IS FREE[8]

25–27 Mar — **Art Basel Hong Kong 2027**
HONG KONG · **NO VENUE, PRICES OR ON-SALE STATUS PUBLISHED YET** ON THE FAIR'S OWN PAGE[6]

PLANNING NOTES

Take the second Yonezu night, not the first. The 30 January date went up on 22 October, which is what a promoter does when night one has gone; resale sites claim the 29th is sold out, which this desk cannot verify, so treat the added date as the realistic route. Prices appear nowhere on the artist's own pages — set an alarm and budget blind.[3]

CP+ is free and gated. There are no walk-ups: registration is online only and opens in early December, so diarise it now rather than in February, and note that the first morning belongs to press and trade.[7]

For a twelve-year-old, Tokyo in the Orsay window is the value. Under-18s are free and advance tickets save ¥200, so a family of three pays one adult fare — but the museum closes **22 December to 3 January**, which is exactly when a Singapore family would go. Book either side of it.[5]

Four things this desk will not list. Christmas Wonderland dates or prices, because the organiser's own site still carries only 2025 highlights and "stay tuned". This December's Singapore marathon, whose own site still serves last year's edition. Light to Night 2027 and the Fringe Festival 2027, both of whose sites redirect to 2026. And *Moulin Rouge!* for the fourth issue running — a show page now exists at the expected address, but **the venue returned an error to every request today**, so there is still nothing read.[9]

SOURCES 1 Esplanade's own festival pages, read at source 5 November 2026. 2 Live Nation Singapore's own listing page, read at source; dates as displayed, **venues and prices not published there**. 3 The artist's own label announcement of 22 October 2026, read at source, for both Singapore nights and the Taipei dates. 4 The organiser's own show page and its trade outlet's preview of 28 September 2026. 5 Tokyo Metropolitan Art Museum's own English exhibition page, read at source: dates, prices, concessions, closures. 6 The tournament's and the fair's own sites, read at source — both carry dates and nothing else; **their ticketing hosts refused this desk.** 7 The organiser's own outline page, read at source, including the registration timing and the renaming notice. 8 The marathon's own English site, read at source. 9 Each organiser's own site, checked 5 November 2026. **The integrated resort, two major ticketing sites and several listings hosts all refused or errored; nothing confirmed only by an aggregator appears above.**

THE TABLE · A MONTH OF RETURNING NAMES

Ng Kuan Chilli Pan Mee opens its fifth outlet at Century Square

The fifth Singapore outlet lands in mid-November at $6.50 a bowl. Of the twelve venues on Eatbook's November list, eleven have already run in this column.

Ng Kuan Chilli Pan Mee has the clearest new peg on this month's biggest openings list, and it is a $6.50 bowl of noodles. The Kuala Lumpur-born chilli pan mee specialist, which this column met eight issues ago, brings its fifth Singapore outlet to Century Square in Tampines in mid-November: signature ban mian at **$6.50**, the dry version **$6.80**, a chicken, fish or pork cutlet bowl at **$8.80**, deep-fried squid tentacles at **$10**. Hours are not yet published and nobody has reviewed this outlet, so it is **too new to call**.[1]

The reason that is the lead is the rest of the list. Of the twelve venues on the month's most-read round-up, **eleven have already appeared in this column** — several of them twice, and one of them in yesterday's issue — which is why this page runs returns with pegs rather than discoveries. That is not a complaint about the restaurants. It is the state of the openings column in Singapore this month, and it is why this page prints opening dates and prices, which are facts, rather than verdicts that do not exist.[2]

Xiao Jiao Tian earns a second run on a real peg: a second outlet, at Wisma Atria on Orchard Road. This desk first covered it fifteen issues ago; what is new is the address and the price list. Bullfrog with pickled chilli is **$39.90** before service, sauerkraut fish **$29.90**, sweet and sour pork **$24.90**, and the free-flow tea, ice cream, snacks and rice have been cut from **$3 to $1.50** a head. The reception is positive and narrow: the one outlet that has eaten there says the bullfrog is the dish to order and that the heat is adjustable — which is also the objection, because a Sichuan loyalist is being sold a deliberately milder room.[1]

Two more return with pegs that are absences rather than events. **rei by Janice Wong**, the no-refined-sugar confectionery line inside the spa at Raffles Sentosa, has now been open long enough for a verdict and **still has none**: no critic, no food-media review, one interview feature. **Creamie Sippies**, whose fourth outlet on Bugis Street carries what is billed as Singapore's first build-your-own banana pudding bar from **$4.50**, has exactly one published line about it. And **Faber Side Cafe & Cellar** in Clementi, an all-day room that becomes a wine-and-tapas cellar at night, holds a **4.7** average on a reservations platform — from **four reviews**. A four-review average is not a verdict.[3]

THE VERDICT · WHERE TO EAT FROM THIS MONTH'S LIST

Ng Kuan Chilli Pan Mee if you want the only genuinely new thing, at six dollars fifty, and you can wait for mid-November. **Xiao Jiao Tian** at Wisma Atria for the bullfrog, asking for the spice a level up. **Faber Side** if you live in Clementi and want the room rather than the review, remembering the ninety-minute seating cap at weekends and the thin parking. **rei** only if you are already at the spa — ring first and ask whether the menu is open to non-guests, because it is served inside it. **Creamie Sippies** is the twelve-year-old's pick and costs four dollars fifty.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT SINGAPORE'S OPENINGS LIST IS ACTUALLY MEASURING

Not one of the five names above carries a published critic's review, and the only one with a proper tasting behind it is a hawker bowl. Which tells you where the cooking is, and also that the openings column has become a press-release relay. Behind it the numbers are harder: Singapore recorded **2,101 food-and-beverage cessations between January and July 2026**, up **25.1 per cent** on a year earlier, against **2,594** new registrations in the same period — roughly four closures for every five launches. Read that honestly: a March spike of 603 in one month partly reflects the registry striking off defunct companies rather than kitchens going dark, and **the government declines to break cessations down at all**, telling Parliament in February only that entities grew 42 per cent across the decade. **What would settle it:** a published count of outlets, not of companies.[4]

HAWKER · TOO NEW TO CALL · SECOND OUTLET · NO CRITIC YET · WALK-IN

SOURCES 1 Eatbook's November 2026 round-up, read at source 5 November 2026, for both venues' addresses, opening timing, dishes and prices, and for the only published tasting notes on either. 2 This magazine's own Table ledger, venue by venue, against that round-up's twelve names. 3 The venue's own listing on a reservations platform for the Clementi prices, hours, seating cap and the four-review average; an interview feature of 7 October 2026 for the confectionery line, which carries no verdict; Eatbook's October round-up for the pudding bar. **Halal status is not published for any of the five and is not asserted here.** 4 Registry figures as reported by two outlets, both read at source, and the Ministry of Energy, Trade and Industry's own parliamentary reply of 4 February 2026, which states that it does not track the breakdown of cessations. **Reddit, Burpple, SETHLUI, Time Out and the Michelin guide all refused or errored for this desk, so no forum or critic sentiment is attributed anywhere on this page.**

CHECKOUT CREDIT · UZBEKISTAN'S NASIYA BOOM

Mirziyoyev signs PP-294 after Uzbekistan's central bank measured credit at 66.5 per cent

Presidential resolution PP-294, signed on 14 August, drags instalment operators into a register from 1 January 2027. Household bank debt reached 243.6 trillion soum on 1 September.

In June 2025 the Central Bank of Uzbekistan went shopping. It picked one product — an iPhone 16 Pro Max with 256 gigabytes, about seventeen million soum at the counter — and bought it, on paper, in every way an Uzbek can buy a telephone. On a twelve-month instalment plan from the shops themselves, the overpayment ran from **27.3 to 44.3 per cent**, which is an effective annual cost of **47 to 73.8 per cent**, mean **66.5**. On bank credit, the same phone cost **14 to 23 per cent** a year, mean 17. One retailer, taking thirty per cent down, wanted **51.9 per cent** above the official price.[1]

The posters in the Tashkent malls say "РАССРОЧКА БЕЗ ПЕРЕПЛАТ 0%" — instalments, no overpayment, nought per cent.[1]

A central bank that has to go shopping to discover the price of money in its own country has lost something more fundamental than a policy lever. It has lost the measurement. And the instrument that took it away is not a foreign import with an English name; it is a word from the pre-Soviet bazaar. **Nasiya** — Uzbek Cyrillic насия, from the Arabic *nasīʾa*, the root meaning postponement or deferment — is defined in Uzbek dictionaries as trade done without cash, on condition of paying later. The same word, used figuratively, means an empty promise: *"your promises are all nasiya."*[2]

This is not the story MERIDIAN has run before under other flags. Malaysia's *Beli Sekarang, Bayar Kemudian* (No. 98) and Mongolia's app loans (No. 104) were both about a shopping toy mutating into subsistence credit. Uzbekistan's case is a different argument: a state that let the price of household money migrate from the policy desk to the shop counter, where nobody was obliged to write it down — and which is now trying to annex it back.[3]

The scale explains the hurry. More than **half of all orders** on Uzum Market, the country's dominant marketplace, are placed on Uzum Nasiya; the company puts **$1.2bn** through consumer instalments and lending in 2025, near triple the year before, on **40 per cent** of the market and twenty million monthly users. One expert count puts the field at one classic pay-in-four operator, about ten large nasiya services, thirty mid-sized ones and more than **250** shop-level schemes. And at the start of 2025, **67 per cent** of the national instalment book sat with ordinary trading companies — not banks, not licensed microfinance, not anybody supervised.[4]

The posters say nought per cent. The regulator measured sixty-six and a half.

Households are already at the edge of it. A Central Bank survey of about **5,800** people across every region, run from 20 to 27 January 2026, found **77 per cent** carrying debt, **61 per cent** struggling to pay on time, mean debt service at **51 per cent** of income and a median of 47 — and roughly **27 per cent** of bank borrowers handing over 76 per cent or more of what they earn. Household bank debt stood at **243.6 trillion soum** on 1 September, up 10.6 per cent in eight months. In the Senate in August, a senator put the growth at more than fivefold in six years.[5]

67%

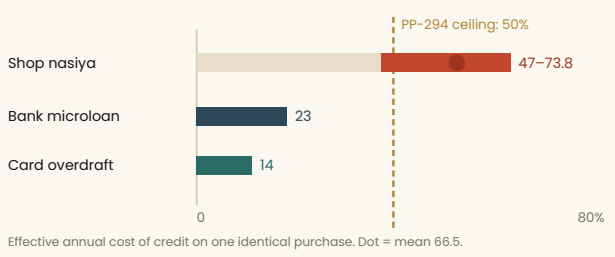
OF UZBEKISTAN'S INSTALMENT BOOK HELD BY ORDINARY SHOPS AT THE START OF 2025 — OUTSIDE ALL SUPERVISION[4]

SOURCES 1 The Central Bank's June 2025 pricing audit as reported in detail by Spot.uz, read at source: the product, the market price, the overpayment and effective-rate ranges for both channels and the worked retailer example. **The Central Bank's own site refused this desk entirely — every statistic attributed to the regulator in these three pages is read from Uzbek press reporting of its documents, not from the bank itself, and that limitation is stated here rather than hidden.** 2 Uzbek and Arabic dictionary entries for *nasiya* / *nasīʾa*, read at source, including the figurative sense. 3 This magazine's own Undercurrent ledger, Nos. 98 and 104. 4 Uzum's own corporate pages and its results release of 12 February 2026; market structure from an expert council member of the national fintech association, quoted by Spot.uz on 11 July 2025; the 67 per cent split from the Tashkent Times's report of the national portfolio at 1 January 2025. **Several platform-scale figures appeared in pieces the Uzbek press marked as advertorial; those are not printed here.** 5 Gazeta.uz's reports of the January 2026 survey and of the Senate session of 7 August 2026; the 1 September debt stock from Anhor.uz. **The fivefold figure is a senator's, not a published central-bank series, and is flagged as such.**

On 14 August 2026 President Shavkat Mirziyoyev signed resolution **PP-294**, registered three days later, and the whole category acquired a legal shape for the first time. From **1 January 2027** nobody may run an instalment service without being entered in a Central Bank register. A single nasiya purchase may not exceed **250 base calculation units** — at the base unit of 440,000 soum lifted on 1 September, that is **110 million soum**. The maximum term is **twelve months**; anything longer is reclassified as a consumer credit agreement. And everything charged above the principal — commissions, fines, penalties — is capped at **50 per cent of the instalment amount per year**.[1]

Read that ceiling against the audit on the previous page. The regulator measured the market at 47 to 73.8 per cent, mean 66.5. The legal limit it has now written is 50. The cap does not sit above the observed range; it cuts through the middle of it.[1]

ONE PHONE, FOUR CHANNELS, AND THE NEW LEGAL CEILING



Effective annual cost of credit on one identical purchase. Dot = mean 66.5.

The Central Bank's own June 2025 audit, one iPhone 16 Pro Max over twelve months, set against the statutory annual ceiling on all charges above principal that takes effect on 1 January 2027. *Meridian* original.[1]

The rest of the resolution reads like a regulator reconstructing a market it can see only from outside. Trading companies must register as operators if quarterly sales exceed **500 million soum** and instalment sales are at least half of them; manufacturers are exempt. Operators may not issue consumer loans or take public funds. Claims may be assigned only to other operators, to microfinance organisations or to banks. And contracts under **three base units** — 1.32 million soum — need not be reported to credit bureaux at all, which is to say the smallest debts stay invisible by design.[1]

The scale of that invisibility has a number attached. Revenue from instalment services grew **twenty-five-fold in six years**, to 201.3 billion soum; **1.9 million** contracts were signed in 2024; the average customer holds **three** nasiya agreements at once; and **82,000 people** hold more than ten. A consultancy study put the combined point-of-sale financing market at **$450m to $500m** of goods in 2023 and forecast it to quadruple by 2027, with observed markups running from nought to **68 per cent** on terms of three to twelve months. The complaints follow the share: of 1,230 e-commerce grievances logged by the consumer protection committee between January and early October 2026, **446** concerned the marketplace and **184** its instalment arm.[4]

Around it the bank has been tightening the instruments it already controls. From 1 March 2026 a borrower's total consumer-loan principal may not exceed **eight times** average monthly income where that income is confirmed, five where it is not; debt service is capped at **50 per cent** of income for banks and non-banks alike; the microloan daily rate ceiling came down from 0.30 to **0.25 per cent**. A decree of 15 July 2026 requires advertisements for credit and instalments to state the added amount and the final cost, and opens microloan contracts with a risk warning that must fill **thirty per cent** of the first section.[2]

> *"The contracts do not clearly state the overpayment, or the real effective interest rate."*

Two facts complicate the re-annexation. The first is ownership: Makesense, the company that operates Uzum Nasiya, is wholly owned by **Nasiya SPV 2 Ltd, registered in the United Kingdom**, and sovereign entities of Oman led more than **$130m** into the group in March 2026 at a pre-money valuation of $2.3bn, alongside Tencent. Uzbek shop-counter debt is now an internationally traded asset. The second is the leak. PP-294 binds intermediaries; direct seller instalments are out of scope — and on **7 October 2026** the state carmaker UzAuto Motors began selling two models on direct, bank-free instalments of **24 and 30 months**, longer than the twelve-month cap the state had just imposed on everybody else.[3]

SOURCES 1 Resolution PP-294 of 14 August 2026, registered 17 August under number 07/26/294/0848, read at source on Uzbekistan's own legislation system: the register, the 250-unit cap, the twelve-month term, the 50 per cent annual ceiling on charges above principal, the trading-company threshold, the assignment rules and the credit-bureau exemption. The base calculation unit of 440,000 soum, and therefore the 110-million-soum figure, from UzDaily's report of the 1 September uplift. 2 Central Bank decision 3618-1, board resolution 31/9 of 5 December 2025, in force 21 January 2026, read at source on the same system; the advertising requirements from the decree of 15 July 2026 as reported by Kun.uz; the microloan rate ceiling from Gazeta.uz. 3 Spot.uz, 17 July 2025, for the ownership of the operating company and its affiliated microfinance volumes; Uzum's own press release of 10 March 2026 for the funding round and valuation; Spot.uz, 7 October 2026, for the state carmaker's direct instalment terms, read at source. 4 Spot.uz, 26 June 2025, for the growth, contract and concentration figures as presented to the Senate; the market-sizing study as reported by the Tashkent Times and Spot.uz, **the consultancy's own file having returned a 404 to this desk**; the complaint counts from Kun.uz, 6 October 2026.

The honest counter-case is that this is financial deepening from near zero, and that the regulator is winning. Household bank debt of 243.6 trillion soum sits against a 2025 economy of **1,849.65 trillion** — about **13.2 per cent** of output, where rich countries run fifty to a hundred. Household lending grew 21.2 per cent year on year while nominal wages grew **18.0** — a gap of three points, not a mania. Problem microloans held steady near **four per cent**. And where the bank has acted, stress fell fast: mortgage debt service from 71 to **49 per cent** of income in a year, car loans from 60 to **37**.[1]

The industry's own sceptics put it more sharply. **Nuriddin Lafizov**, chief executive of Alif Uzbekistan, argues that "*BNPL is not a replacement for banks, it is a complement*", and that instalments should not be equated with microlending when bank loans themselves run at twenty-four to fifty per cent a year. **Otabek Aliaskarov**, of the national fintech association's expert council, warns against a "*shock effect*"; he thinks more than a thousand organisations may qualify as operators.[2]

> ***"It really is an alarming situation." — Sanjar Nosirov, Deputy Chairman, Central Bank of Uzbekistan***

And yet the regulator will not say that. Asked in the Senate on 7 August whether the picture was worrying, the deputy chairman, **Sanjar Nosirov**, answered: "*You put it quite rightly. It really is an alarming situation*" — before conceding the limit of his own instrument: the debt-service rule "*will not stop the debt burden directly, but it will raise people's informed awareness*". His chairman, **Timur Ishmetov**, had already named the defect in June 2025, and it is a defect of measurement rather than of price: "*the contracts do not clearly state the overpayment, or the real effective interest rate.*"[3]

There are two precedents, and they are not comforting. The nearer one is next door. After a consumer-credit boom, Kazakhstan's president announced in June 2019 that the state would simply pay off small unsecured debts — up to **300,000 tenge** a borrower for anyone owing under three million. The government guessed about half a million people. By September it had written off more than **138 billion tenge**, roughly **$357m**, for over **two million** citizens, and cancelled 33 billion more in fines for 1.4 million others. That is what a Central Asian government does when household credit turns political, and the precedent Tashkent hopes not to need.[4]

The further one is the full version of the same film. South Korea lifted its cash-advance ceiling in 1999 to stimulate consumption; advances went from **48 trillion won** that year to **358 trillion** in 2002. By the end of 2003 the country had **3.72 million registered credit delinquents** — close to sixteen per cent of an economically active population of 22.9 million — and one card issuer alone reported a loss of 5.6 trillion won. The pattern rhymes: a state that wants consumption, a credit instrument priced at the point of sale, and a regulator that tightens only once it is universal.[5]

Which leaves the word. Uzbekistan's framework law on Islamic banking took effect on **29 June 2026**; twelve microfinance organisations now offer Islamic products, and of the 22 billion soum extended from January to May, **63 per cent** was *murabaha* — described in the Uzbek press as a cost-plus instalment sale. The classical jurists built an entire prohibition around *riba al-nasīʾa*, the increase on the deferred sale. Uzbekistan has now legalised the transaction under its Arabic name, with the markup disclosed, in the same year it moved to register the version that calls itself nought per cent. The country does not need a new instrument. It needs the number written on the contract.[6]

13.2%

HOUSEHOLD BANK DEBT AS A SHARE OF OUTPUT — THE COUNTER-CASE, AND THIS DESK'S OWN ARITHMETIC[1]

WHAT WOULD SHOW THIS DESK WRONG

If microloan arrears stay near four per cent through 2027, the share of borrowers holding several obligations stops climbing — it went from **43 to 53 per cent** during 2025 — and self-reported debt service falls from 51 per cent of income the way mortgage service already has, then this is simply a young country buying its first refrigerators on credit, and the framing on these pages is wrong.[1]

SOURCES 1 Output and wage series read directly from Uzbekistan's own statistics service as published data; the debt-to-output ratio is this desk's arithmetic on those two figures and is labelled as such. Lending growth, arrears, the debt-service improvements and the multiple-obligation share from Gazeta.uz's reports of the Central Bank's 2025 financial stability review. **No verified inflation print was obtainable, so the wage figure is nominal only and is not deflated.** 2 Spot.uz, 11 July 2025 and 27 August 2026, read at source, for all three industry voices. 3 Gazeta.uz's report of the Senate session of 7 August 2026 for both of the deputy chairman's remarks, and Spot.uz, 26 June 2025, for the chairman's. 4 The Kazakh prime minister's office and the Astana Times, September 2019, read at source, for the decree's terms and the final totals. 5 Korean business press and contemporaneous American reporting of the 2003 card crisis, read at source. 6 Kun.uz, 16 June 2026, read at source, for the Islamic-banking date, the volumes and the *murabaha* share and description.

THE LAST WORD

The missing mechanism

A central bank in Tashkent could not find out what credit costs in its own country, so it went to the shops and bought a telephone eleven different ways (p21). The answer was sixty-six and a half per cent a year. Every poster above every counter said nought. The regulation that followed caps charges at fifty — a line drawn straight through the middle of the range the regulator had just measured, on a market where two-thirds of the lending sits with shops that file nothing.

The same shape repeats through the book. A palace reaches for the word treason and its own legal affairs minister says no motive has been established (p3). A parliament raises a fine tenfold on an Act that has never collected a dollar, because the thing it lacks is not a bigger number but evidence from another country (p5). A minister resigns for a control room that is still twenty per cent short of controllers (p4). A company reports its largest quarter and guides its margin down a point (p7).

And the smaller ones rhyme. A headphone at three thousand seven hundred and ninety-nine dollars whose every claim is its maker's, because nobody has measured it (p10). An album at number one on sixty-eight thousand copies across twenty editions of itself (p11). A school phone ban that moved nothing measurable, beside a study that found the harm sitting at ten o'clock at night, at home (p13). An antioxidant that made the muscle worse because the thing it mopped up was the signal (p18). The announcement is never the mechanism. Ask what would have to be true.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

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A note on method. Read at source this edition: Uzbekistan's resolution PP-294 and a central-bank decision on its own legislation system; Singapore's ministerial speeches and the environment agency's release; the United States Treasury's daily par and real yield curves (p14); a chip maker's results and call transcript; two medical journals' abstracts, with every interval they print; and every event on p19 on its promoter's own page. **Reddit refused every desk that wanted it, so no forum sentiment is attributed anywhere in this issue, and Uzbekistan's central bank refused us entirely — p21 says so twice.**